

World in Brief: Canada strikes back at America with tariffs; Iran vows sanctions retaliation



Photograph: Reuters

Canada announced **retaliatory tariffs** on \$20bn-worth of American goods, from September 8th, [matching levies](#) imposed by America [after trade talks collapsed](#). Canada will double existing tariffs on steel and aluminium to 50% and impose tariffs of between 15% and 50% on goods such as furniture, clothing, dairy and machinery. Mark Carney, Canada's prime minister, had promised to match America's tariffs.

Iran vowed to retaliate against America's expanded **sanctions regime**, having warned that "not a single drop of oil" would leave the Gulf if the pressure continued. On Monday **Scott Bessent**, America's treasury secretary, threatened [broader measures](#) against **Iran's** trading partners, although he did not name any countries. China, a large buyer of Iranian oil, said its trade with Iran "should not be disrupted".

Oman said it discussed a proposed framework with Iran to create "a temporary joint navigation corridor" through the **Strait of Hormuz**. Oman's foreign ministry said the two countries are negotiating a permanent route, as well as a joint operation to clear

mines from [the waterway](#). Earlier, Donald Trump claimed that America's navy had removed or detonated "all mines" in the strait.

John Ratcliffe, the head of America's CIA, arrived in Moscow for unannounced talks with **Russian** officials. Neither side revealed the purpose of the spy chief's visit. Earlier flight-tracking data showed an American military-transport aircraft had flown to Moscow from a military base in America via Latvia, though the Kremlin initially denied knowledge of a planned visit.

Two people died from **measles** in America, the country's first deaths from the disease this year. America is currently grappling with its largest measles outbreak in decades: the Centres for Disease Control and Prevention has confirmed 2,777 cases this year and warns that [vaccination rates among children](#) are falling. [In 2025](#) three people died from measles in America, the first reported deaths since 2015.

Shares in **SpaceX**, [Elon Musk's rocketry firm](#), rose after the company announced that it will spend \$100bn building a new launch site in Louisiana. The facility will eventually support "thousands" of annual [Starship rocket](#) flights, SpaceX said. Construction begins next year. Starship is currently launched from the company's Starbase facility in Texas. SpaceX is also adding a new launch pad in Florida.

Dolly Parton, a country-music legend, died in Nashville aged 80. Born into poverty in Tennessee, she became one of the best-selling female singer-songwriters, with more than 100m records sold globally. Her hits include "9 to 5" and "Jolene". Over her seven-decade career she ventured into acting, [theme-parks](#) and philanthropy, in particular improving children's literacy.

Figure of the day: 21%, the proportion of votes Volodymyr Zelensky would receive in a presidential election, according to a poll. [Our story explores](#) Ukraine's growing political divisions.

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The race to succeed Lindsey Graham



Photograph: Getty Images

On Tuesday Republicans in South Carolina will go to the polls for the fourth time this summer to choose their candidate to replace [Lindsey Graham](#), a senator who died in July after more than two decades on Capitol Hill. His sister, Darline Graham, appointed by the governor to fill his seat temporarily, faces Ralph Norman, a congressman and member of the House Freedom Caucus, a hardline conservative group. Ms Graham has clinched an endorsement from Donald Trump. On Friday he flew to Myrtle Beach to campaign with her.

She is the strong favourite, but has had a poor campaign. In a debate last week Ms Graham stumbled over a question about China and Taiwan before conceding that “national security is not my thing”. The gaffe highlighted how green she is on the foreign-policy issues that [her brother](#) made central to his career. Republicans looking for someone to fill his role as a hawkish voice against MAGA isolationism may be disappointed.

Trump's economic war on Iran may backfire



Photograph: Getty Images

On Monday [Scott Bessent](#), America's treasury secretary, announced “[Operation Economic Outcast](#)” against Iran. While continuing its blockade of Iranian oil exports, America plans to increase pressure on the regime's trading partners and institutions that help it move money. Mr Bessent warned of new sanctions targeting sectors such as technology and shipping. But America took no immediate action against individual countries, such as China, which buys more than 80% of Iranian crude exports.

Iran is in dire economic straits. Its oil exports have collapsed, the rial has hit a record low and inflation is soaring. But squeezing it further will be difficult. China, for one, may resist American pressure. And the Iranian regime could respond with force, by attacking countries that co-operate with America or targeting energy facilities and ships in the Gulf. Donald Trump hopes economic strangulation will succeed where bombs and diplomacy failed. It could instead trigger another round of fighting.

Lego builds on its success



Photograph: Getty Images

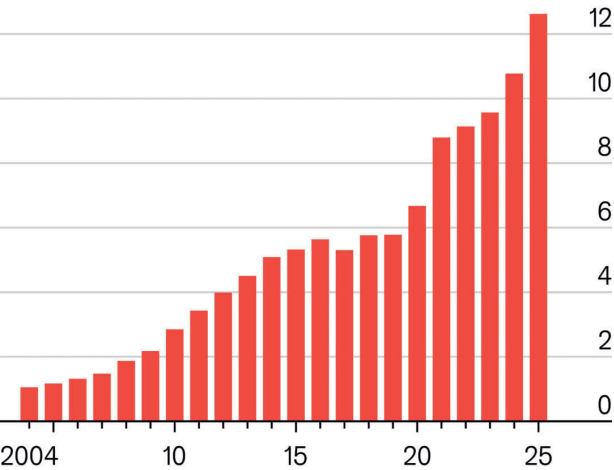
Around two decades ago Lego nearly went bankrupt. The company had strayed from its multicoloured interlocking bricks as video games and digital entertainment took hold. That lesson stuck and Lego returned to its roots. Its sales have since [grown](#) more than ten-fold to Dkr83.5bn (\$13bn)—more than those of Mattel and Hasbro, its two biggest rivals, combined. On Tuesday it reported net profits of Dkr8.6bn, an increase of a third on a year before.

Nostalgia is one building block of its success. Lego is courting grown-ups happy to splurge on pricey collector sets. Replicas of the Sagrada Familia and the Eiffel tower, designed to be showcased rather than played with, sell for more than £500 (\$680). [Kidults](#) now account for a fifth of sales.

The digital threat has not disappeared. Lego has reportedly tripled its software-engineering workforce since 2022 as a result. Its YouTube channel boasts more than 21m subscribers. Yet the core of [Lego's mission](#) remains its colourful plastic bricks—virtually unchanged since the 1950s.

Brick by brick

Lego, revenue, \$bn



Source: Company reports

A worrying turn for Zambian democracy



Photograph: Martin Mbangweta/Xinhua News Agency/eyevine

Last week Hakainde Hichilema was declared the winner of [Zambia's presidential election](#). The president's opponents have until Tuesday to challenge his re-election in court. There is one problem: on Monday the courts were closed indefinitely with authorities citing security concerns. That leaves little time for Brian Mundubile, the main opposition candidate.

Police have also summoned Mr Mundubile as the government investigates what it says was a planned insurrection. On August 14th security forces shot dead one of Mr Mundubile's associates, and arrested 11 others. He has sought protection from the UN, claiming that he won the election and the result was stolen from him. A group of Zambian churches, which monitored the count, thinks that Mr Hichilema won, but by less than the electoral commission claims. The dispute marks a worrying turn for a country whose record of peaceful transfers of power has long set it apart in the region.

A ruling on one of Turkey's political prisoners



Photograph: Serra Akcan/NARphotos/eyevine

On Tuesday Europe's top human-rights court will rule once again on the imprisonment of Osman Kavala, a Turkish philanthropist who has spent almost nine years behind bars. In 2019 the European Court of Human Rights ordered his release, finding that his detention was politically motivated (Turkey had accused him of organising the Gezi Park protests, anti-government demonstrations that swept the country in 2013). The [Turkish government](#) did not comply. After a retrial, Mr Kavala was convicted in 2022 of attempting to overthrow the government and sentenced to life in prison.

The court will now decide whether the trial which led to that conviction violated his rights. Yet even if the court rules in Mr Kavala's favour, it may make little difference. The [EU](#), once vocal about his imprisonment, has grown quieter as Turkey (a [NATO](#) member) has become more important to its security. As such, Strasbourg's judges are more likely to offer Mr Kavala vindication than freedom.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: What type of creature did Daryl Hannah play in the film “Splash”?

Monday: What title did Charlemagne take in 800^{AD} with the help of Pope Leo III?

Monday's quiz question was missing in yesterday's edition. Sorry

*All knowledge degenerates into
probability.*

David Hume